CHAPTER 59 National Commission for Women

Establishment

The Committee on Status of Women in India (set up by the Government of India), in 1974, recommended the constitution of a National Commission for Women to fulfil the surveillance functions and to facilitate redressal of grievances and accelerate the socio-economic development of women. Again, the successive women-related committees, commissions and plans including the National Perspective Plan for Women (1988) have also recommended the constitution of such an apex body for women. Accordingly, the National Commission for Women was constituted in 1992 for protecting, promoting and safeguarding the interests and rights of women.

The Commission is an autonomous statutory (and not a constitutional) body. It was established under a legislation enacted by the Parliament, namely the National Commission for Women Act, 1990.[1] The Ministry of Women and Child Development of the Government of India is the nodal ministry for the Commission.[2]

The Commission has a wide mandate covering almost all aspects of women's development and empowerment. Its specific objectives are as follows:

1. To review the constitutional and legal safeguards for women
2. To recommend remedial legislative measures
3. To facilitate the redressal of grievances
4. To advise the government on all policy matters affecting women

Composition

The Commission is a multi-member body consisting of a chairperson, five members and a member-secretary. The chairperson should be someone who is committed to the cause of women. The five members should be from amongst persons of ability, integrity and standing who have had experience in law or legislation, trade unionism, management of an industry or an organisation committed to increasing the employment potential of women, women's voluntary organisations (including women activists), administration, economic development, health, education or social welfare. However, at least one member each should belong to the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, respectively.



The member-secretary should be (i) an expert in the field of management, organisational structure or sociological movement, or (ii) an officer who is a member of a Civil Service of the Union or an All-India Service or holds a civil post under the Union.